Imperial DoLS GTA Allocator
Guide for PhD Students

Overview

The GTA Allocator helps match PhD students to practical demonstrating sessions. You can browse practicals, submit your preferences, check and confirm your allocations and, after the main allocation, volunteer for any sessions that still need GTAs.

Website: https://tonysouthall.github.io/GTA_allocator/

How It Works

1. **Browse** available practicals and their requirements
2. **Rank** the practicals you'd like to demonstrate, in order of preference
3. **Submit** your preferences before the deadline
4. **Check** your allocations once the DPS has run the allocation
5. **Confirm** or decline each allocation, using the buttons in your allocation email or under "Check Your Allocations" on the website
6. **Volunteer** for any places still empty after the allocation, on the "Open GTA slots" page (first come, first served)
7. **Receive** automatic email reminders before your practicals
8. **Rate** your GTA experience after each practical to help us improve

> ⚠️ **Commitment: Sign Up = Show Up**
> **Complete GTA training first.** Only sign up if you have completed the department's GTA training (see GTA Training below).
> **Signing up is a firm commitment.** Practicals cannot run safely without their GTAs, so a withdrawal can mean a session is cancelled for hundreds of students.
> **Only withdraw for a genuine emergency.** A clash with a course, an unexpected experiment or a lab meeting is not a reason to cancel, so check your timetable before you sign up.
> If you do have to withdraw, decline the session in the app straight away (the first reserve is then offered the place automatically) and email the convenor. Withdrawing without a very good reason may reduce your priority for future allocations.

Submitting Your Preferences

Step 1: Enter Your Details

- Your Name
- Imperial Email - use your Imperial email, and the same address every time. This is where your allocation and reminder emails are sent, and how you check your allocations.

Step 2: Select Your Areas of Expertise

Tick all areas that apply to you. This helps match you to practicals where your skills are most useful.

Step 3: Confirm Your Department

Only PhD students registered in the Department of Life Sciences (DoLS) are eligible to GTA for departmental practicals. Please confirm your department when submitting your preferences.

Step 4: Rank Your Preferred Practicals

- Click on a practical to add it to your preferences
- The order you click determines your ranking (1st choice, 2nd choice, etc.)
- Click again to remove a practical from your list
- Your current ranking is displayed below the practical list
- Only want to volunteer for empty places later? You can submit without selecting any practicals. This registers you as a GTA so you can use the "Open GTA slots" page.

💡 **Tips for ranking:**
✅ Rank as many practicals as you're willing to do
✅ Put your most preferred practical first
✅ Consider the dates — make sure you're available!
✅ Check the expertise tags — you'll enjoy practicals that match your skills
✅ Click the 📄 View Handbook link to learn more about what's involved
✅ Read the handbook before your practical — this is expected of all GTAs

Step 5: Confirm Training and Commitment

Tick the two required boxes to confirm that:

- you have completed the department's GTA training
- you understand that GTA sessions are a firm commitment, and you will only withdraw from a confirmed session in a genuine emergency

The form will not submit until both boxes are ticked.

You can also tick **"I'm happy to be placed on other practicals I didn't choose"**. If you leave this unticked, you will only ever be allocated to practicals you selected.

Step 6: Submit

Click "Submit Preferences" to send your choices. You'll see a confirmation message.

Note: If you need to change your preferences after submitting, contact the DPS.

Understanding the Practical Listings

Information	What it means
Practical Name	The name/title of the practical session
Course Code	The module code (you'll need this for pay claims)
Date	When the practical takes place
Time	The advertised start and end time(s), and the total session length in hours
Slots	Number of GTAs needed
Location	Where the practical takes place
Deadline	Submit your preferences by the end of this day

View Handbook	Link to practical materials. READ THIS before your practical — it is expected of all GTAs.

Before Your Practical: Read the Handbook

Read the Handbook Before Your Practical
Every practical listing includes a link to a handbook. You are expected to read this before attending. The handbook covers what you need to know to demonstrate effectively: the practical content, safety information, and what students will be doing.
If no handbook is available, contact the course convenor in advance to ask what preparation is needed.

GTA Training

All GTAs must complete the GTA training programme **before signing up** for sessions.
Training is coordinated by **Anita Hall (anita.hall@imperial.ac.uk)** and covers:

- What is expected of you as a demonstrator
- How to support students effectively in a practical setting

Keep up to date with training
Training sessions are scheduled at the start of term. Check communications from the DPS for dates. If you are unsure whether you have completed the required training, contact the DPS.

Checking Your Allocations

1. Go to the GTA Allocator website
2. Scroll down to "Check Your Allocations"
3. Enter your Imperial email address
4. Your allocated practicals are displayed with the date, times, location, teaching staff and handbook link
5. Use the **Confirm** and **Decline** buttons to respond to each allocation. The app only says a session is confirmed once it has been saved.

If the page says your allocations couldn't be loaded, this is a temporary problem connecting to Google, not a problem with your email. Click **Try again**, or open the site in a private/incognito window.

To look up any practical this term, including ones you weren't allocated to, use **Browse all practicals** at the bottom of the page.

After the Allocation: Open GTA Slots

Once the main allocation has been run, any sessions that still need GTAs (for example, because someone declined) are listed on the **Open GTA slots** page. Click the green "Open GTA slots" button at the top of the website, or go to https://tonysouthall.github.io/GTA_allocator/?view=slots

Places are **first come, first served**:

- Enter the email you registered with, and tick the box to confirm you have completed GTA training and understand the commitment
- Click **Volunteer** on a session that suits you. You are confirmed straight away, and the convenor is told automatically
- You will receive a confirmation email with the date, times, location and handbook link

- The page won't let you take a session that clashes with one you already have, or a session that is today
- Sessions next term are not listed here; they go through that term's normal allocation

If you haven't registered as a GTA yet, submit your details in Student View first (you don't need to select any practicals), then return to the Open GTA slots page.

Please only take sessions you can commit to, and leave some for others. The same commitment applies as for allocated sessions, and you must be registered with the casual payroll team before the session.

Email Reminders

You'll automatically receive email reminders for your allocated practicals:

- 7 days before - Advance notice to prepare (use this time to read the handbook!)
- 1 day before - Final reminder

Reminders include the practical name, date, times, location, teaching staff, course code for your pay claim, and a link to the handbook if available.
Important: if you receive a reminder and can no longer attend (which should only happen in a genuine emergency), decline the session in the app straight away and email the convenor, so the reserve can be offered the place.

> ⚠️ **Casual Payroll Registration**
> You must be registered with the casual payroll team **before any session**. You cannot be paid for a session you worked before your registration was in place.
> **Registration lasts 51 weeks.** If you registered at the start of last academic year it has lapsed and you need to re-register. Re-registration is quick (a few hours to a day). A brand-new registration takes a couple of days, and longer at the start of term when every department is registering at once — so do this now rather than the week of your practical.
> To register or re-register, email Rebecca Lewis (rebecca.lewis1@imperial.ac.uk) with your name, email and CID number, saying whether you have been registered before.
> **If you are on a visa:** your registration must be completed and confirmed before you do any session. This cannot be sorted out afterwards. If you are unsure how GTA work fits with the conditions of your visa, contact the International Student Support team before signing up.

Pay for Prepwork

You are not paid for time spent preparing for a practical unless you have agreed this in advance with the course convenor. If you expect to need paid prep time beyond reading the handbook, discuss and agree this with the convenor before the practical.

Pay for Actual Hours Worked

Each practical listing shows advertised Session Times (Morning, Afternoon, or both) and the total advertised hours. You are paid for the hours you actually work, not the advertised hours — if a practical finishes earlier than advertised, your pay will reflect the actual time worked.

Summative Marking

GTAs should not carry out summative marking. Your role is to support students during the practical; summative assessment of student work remains the responsibility of academic staff. If you are asked to do summative marking, please contact the DPS.

Rating Your GTA Experience

After completing a confirmed practical, you will see a "Rate Your GTA Experience" section when you check your allocations. You can:

- Give a star rating (1–5) for the practical
- Leave optional comments about your experience

Ratings are reviewed by the DPS and help us improve the GTA programme. Your feedback is valued. You'll also get an automatic email on the next working day after your practical, with a direct link to a short feedback form — so you don't need to remember to check back yourself.

How the Allocation Works

The allocation is designed to be fair to everyone:

- Students with fewer previous demonstrating hours get priority — this ensures opportunities are shared fairly
- Your preferences are respected - the system tries to give everyone their top choices
- Multiple rounds - everyone gets one slot before anyone gets a second
- You are only placed on practicals you selected, unless you ticked that you are happy to be placed on others
- You will never be given two sessions that overlap in time
- Reserves - up to 2 backup GTAs per practical. If an allocated GTA declines, the first reserve is offered the place automatically by email

This means you might not always get your first choice, but the system ensures fair distribution across all students.

After the main allocation, any remaining places are filled first come, first served through the Open GTA slots page (see above).

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Can I change my preferences after submitting?
A: Contact the DPS (t.southall@imperial.ac.uk) if you need to make changes.

Q: What if I'm not available for a practical I've been allocated?
A: Decline it in the app (under "Check Your Allocations", or using the button in your allocation email) as soon as possible, and email the convenor. The first reserve is offered the place automatically. Once you have confirmed, please only withdraw for a genuine emergency; withdrawing without good reason may reduce your priority in future rounds.

Q: How many practicals can I be allocated?
A: The default maximum is 3 practicals per student, but this may vary. You can set your own maximum when submitting preferences.

Q: What's the course code for?
A: You'll need the course code when submitting your pay claim for GTA work. It's included in your reminder emails.

Q: I didn't receive a reminder email - what should I do?
A: Check your spam/junk folder. If it's not there, verify your email address is correct and contact the DPS.

Q: I am a mature student or will be on a field course during term — can I still be a GTA?
A: Potentially yes, in specific circumstances. The DPS will consider your situation, but any arrangement requires agreement from you, the relevant course director, and that it would not impact your degree. Contact the DPS to discuss.

Q: I am from a department outside Life Sciences - can I sign up?

A: No. Only PhD students registered in the Department of Life Sciences (DoLS) are eligible to GTA for departmental practicals.

Q: Can I pick up extra sessions after the allocation?
A: Yes. Sessions that still need GTAs are listed on the Open GTA slots page and are first come, first served. See "After the Allocation: Open GTA Slots".

Q: I haven't done GTA training yet. Can I sign up?
A: No. Please complete the training first (contact Anita Hall, anita.hall@imperial.ac.uk), then sign up.

Q: I clicked Confirm but my session still isn't showing as confirmed. What should I do?
A: Click Confirm again; the app now tells you if a confirmation couldn't be saved. If it still doesn't work, email the DPS.

Q: How do I rate my GTA experience?
A: Once your allocation status is "Confirmed", a rating section will appear when you check your allocations. Select the practical, give a star rating, and optionally add comments.

Q: Will I be paid for the advertised hours, even if the practical finishes early?
A: No. You are paid for the hours you actually work, not the advertised hours. If a practical finishes earlier than advertised, your pay will reflect the actual time worked.

Need Help?

Contact the Director of Postgraduate Studies:
Tony Southall — t.southall@imperial.ac.uk